

SOME WAYS TO BEAT The New Monster In Our Environment



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The rapid growth of information, communication and entertainment technology sectors is ratcheting a viral effect on the manufacturing industries, leading to phenomenal growth in volume, variety and applications. The booming demand, rapid changes in technology, media (tapes, software, MP3), falling prices and planned obsolescence are resulting in the fast growth of e-waste.

Electronic and electrical equipment (EEE) when discarded is called e-waste. These include discarded computers, office electronic equipment, electronic entertainment devices, mobile phones, television sets, refrigerators, microwave ovens and electric appliances and devices, among others. India is likely to generate three million metric tons (MT) of e-waste per year by 2018 from the present 1.85 million MT, as per an ASSOCHAM-Frost & Sullivan study. Mumbai with 120,000MT tops the list followed by Delhi-NCR (98,000MT) and Bengaluru (92,000MT).

Fig. 1: An e-waste dump largely made up of discarded electronic goods (Image courtesy: www.childfund.org)



The study also points out that Chennai, Kolkata, Ahmedabad, Hyderabad and Pune are generating 67,000MT, 55,000MT, 36,000MT, 32,000MT and 26,000MT of e-waste per year, respectively. Computer equipment accounts for almost 70 per cent of e-waste material, followed by telecommunication equipment (12 per cent), electrical equipment (eight per cent) and medical equipment (seven per cent). Other equipment such as household e-scraps account for the remaining four per cent.

This estimate includes second-hand equipment and devices imported from developed countries for reuse, which mostly end up in unauthorised recycling yards either immediately or once the re-used product is discarded. Complex and ambiguous definitions of second-hand electronic equipment has made it difficult for the customs department to trace, identify and stop the illegal inflow of e-waste into the country. The government recently informed Apple that it will not allow import and sale of second-hand consumer products as it contributed to electronic waste being dumped in India. The discard rate of EEE is shown in Table I.

Most businesses and individuals sell their discarded EEE to informal recyclers for ease and ready money without realis-

TABLE I
THE DISCARD RATE OF EEE

Item	Estimated discard rate
Mobile telephones	1 to 3 years
PCs	Every 2 years
Cameras	3 to 5 years
Televisions	10-15 years
Refrigerators and washing machines	10-15 years
IT accessories	Very fast

Source: Guidelines for Environmentally Sound Management of E-Waste, Ministry of Environment & Forests, Central Pollution Control Board, Delhi